Week 4 | Data, Power, and Classification: Who Decides What Counts?

Reflection

This week in the workshop we did a small group exercise: we were given a pile of everyday objects (well, actually images of objects) and asked to classify them into categories. It sounded easy, but it quickly got messy. We started with simple groups like "food" and "not food," but then someone asked where a plastic apple should go. It looks like food, but it isn't. Then we had a picture of a mug with a plant in it—was it "kitchenware" or "garden"? We ended up arguing for ten minutes about where to put things. That small exercise taught me more about classification than any lecture could. Categories are not natural. They are decisions, and someone always has to decide what gets included and what gets left out.

This connects directly to D'Ignazio and Klein's (2020) chapter "What Gets Counted Counts" from *Data Feminism*. They argue that classification systems are not neutral; they reflect and reinforce power hierarchies. Binaries like male/female, citizen/non-citizen, or employed/unemployed often erase people who do not fit neatly into either box. In our group exercise, the plastic apple and the mug-plant did not fit, and our instinct was to force them into one category or leave them out. That is exactly what happens in data collection on a much bigger scale. D'Ignazio and Klein show that when

classification systems ignore ambiguity, they produce data that misrepresents reality—and that has real consequences for real people.

Crawford's (2021) chapter on "Data" in *The Atlas of AI* added another layer. She argues that data is not simply "collected" but extracted, often through hidden labour and exploitative practices. Data is framed as raw material, but it is always processed, categorised, and made useful for someone. This made me rethink my own experience with social media. I use Instagram regularly, and I realised I have consented to a huge amount of data collection without really knowing what happens to it. My location, my likes, my scrolling behaviour, my face in photos—all of that is classified and used to predict what I will do next. Crawford's point is that this is not just a technical process. It is a political and economic one. The classification systems behind these platforms decide what counts as "engagement" or "relevant content," and those decisions shape what I see and how I feel.

The prompts for this week asked me to think about hierarchies and binaries in data collection and to reflect on my own consent as a user. I have to admit: I don't really know how my data is used. I have never read Instagram's terms of service properly. That is partly because they are long and confusing, but it is also because the platform does not want me to understand. D'Ignazio and Klein's feminist data principles suggest that classification should be transparent, participatory, and accountable. My own experience shows the

opposite: classification is hidden, non-negotiable, and designed to serve the platform, not me.

So what did this week teach me about digital methods and digital media? It taught me that data is never just data. It is always shaped by decisions about what to count, how to categorise, and who benefits. The workshop exercise seemed trivial, but it revealed something important: classification is a power operation. As a digital media student, I need to ask not just "what does this data show?" but "who decided what counts as data in the first place?" For my portfolio website, I have added a Week 4 page with my group's classification notes, a screenshot of our messy categories, and a short reflection on what got left out. I also looked up Instagram's privacy policy and noted one sentence that I found particularly vague about how my data is shared with third parties. That was an eye-opener.

Portfolio evidence: [insert link to your portfolio website Week 4 page here]

References

Crawford, K. (2021) 'Data', in *The Atlas of AI: Power, Politics, and the Planetary Costs of Artificial Intelligence*. New Haven: Yale University Press, pp. 89–122.

D'Ignazio, C. and Klein, L. F. (2020) 'What gets counted counts', in *Data Feminism*. Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press, pp. 97–123